known by the name of Devi, having cohabited with him, gave birth to a most noble son.'[21] A later account is positively loquacious by comparison: Ashoka, it says, 'made her his wife; and she was (afterwards) with child by him and bore in Ujjeni a beautiful boy, Mahinda, and when two years had passed (she bore) a daughter, Samghamita.'[22] Either way, this is the defining incident recounted in relation to Ashoka's life in Avanti, an instantaneous falling in love even before reaching his destination Ujjayini, and the birth of two children to the couple in the course of his obviously long sojourn there.

While historians agree with these aspects of the story, there has been enormous disagreement about other threads. One strange spat—at least that is how it appears to those who engage with the ideas of investigators much after they are played out—concerns the legal status of this relationship, and whether Ashoka did or did not marry Devi. The historian Romila Thapar, in her book titled *Asoka and the Decline of the Mauryas*, is certain that Devi was 'not legally married' to Ashoka since, among other things, there is no reference to a marriage in the *Dipavamsa*.[23] Given the brevity of the evidence, this is not surprising. In fact, such sources don't describe a great deal else that we know to have transpired in the life of Ashoka.[24] The disagreement has also been fuelled by differing interpretations of the word *samvasa* in the Sri Lankan chronicles. The word was initially translated in a way that suggested sexual relations outside marriage, but is supposed to mean co-residence, presumably within a conjugal relationship.[25] And then there is the odd argument that the absence of a 'legal' marriage could be the reason why, after Ashoka's consecration, Devi did not become his chief queen ('since she would have been debarred from performing the duties of the chief queen').[26] Given that this prince showed himself self-willed in going against the tradition of primogeniture by which most princes ascended the throne—he snatched the throne of Magadha at his father's death—it seems to me more likely that Devi was the wife of Ashoka,